

Some Voters Are Asking AI Chatbots for Help With Their Ballots

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Voting in the 2026 **midterm elections** has already started in the United States, and some voters are trying something new to get ready. They are asking AI **chatbots** to help them research the candidates and races on their ballots, NPR reports.

In Morgantown, West Virginia, Adam Johnson, 40, spent hours one September evening going over his ballot with ChatGPT, a **chatbot** made by the company OpenAI. He asked it to list every race on his ballot and then to compare candidates based on the values he cares about. Johnson said the **chatbot** is "kind of a people pleaser" that tends to speak positively about whatever he leans toward.

Other voters told NPR they use **chatbots** to learn about smaller local races that get little news coverage, to make tables comparing candidates, and to check whether claims they see online are true. Lisa Veldran, 65, of Madison, Wisconsin, used Google's Gemini **chatbot** to compare two candidates for governor. She said it can be a research tool, but people should remember who pays to build these bots and why. In Pennsylvania, author Lakshmi Iyer used the **chatbot** Claude to build a volunteer website that helps voters look up who is on their ballot.

Experts urge caution. Rafael Batista, a fellow at Johns Hopkins University who studies how AI shapes people's experiences, said **chatbots** may pick information that pushes users further toward what they already believe. Because AI companies do not explain how their models choose sources, he said, it is hard to know what **biases** they carry. OpenAI said it monitors its models to keep answers **politically neutral**.

Chatbots can also "**hallucinate**," which means giving false or made-up answers. Batista suggested that voters keep their personal preferences hidden when they ask questions.

Word Treasure

midterm elections -- U.S. elections held halfway through a president's term.

bias -- A leaning that can make information unfair or one-sided.

hallucinate -- When a chatbot gives false or made-up answers.

politically neutral -- Not favoring any political side.

chatbot -- A computer program that answers typed questions.

Break it down

Lead: voters turn to AI chatbots during the midterms

Example: Adam Johnson researches his ballot with ChatGPT

Other uses: local races, comparison tables and a voter website

Expert caution about bias and persuasion

Chatbot mistakes and advice for voters

Why it matters

As AI tools become part of how people learn about elections, understanding their strengths and weaknesses helps voters make informed choices.

Test what you remember

1. According to NPR, what new thing are some voters trying?
 - (A) Voting only by mail
 - (B) Voting twice
 - (C) Skipping local races
 - (D) Asking AI chatbots to research their ballots
2. Which company makes ChatGPT?
 - (A) Johns Hopkins
 - (B) Google
 - (C) NPR
 - (D) OpenAI
3. What did Lisa Veldran use Gemini to do?
 - (A) Plan meals
 - (B) Build a voter website
 - (C) Find a job
 - (D) Compare two candidates for governor
4. What did Veldran say people should remember about chatbots?
 - (A) That they never use the internet
 - (B) That they are always right
 - (C) Who pays to build them and why
 - (D) That they only speak Spanish
5. Why does Rafael Batista say it is hard to know chatbots' biases?
 - (A) Voters hide their questions
 - (B) Chatbots refuse to talk about politics
 - (C) Chatbots are too new to test
 - (D) AI companies do not explain how their models choose sources
6. What did Batista suggest voters do when asking chatbots questions?
 - (A) Keep their personal preferences hidden
 - (B) Ask the same question twice
 - (C) Only ask about the Senate
 - (D) Share all their opinions first

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: D 4: C 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

- 1. Voters:** Find chatbots useful for researching candidates and checking claims, while staying aware of their limits.
- 2. Rafael Batista, Johns Hopkins University:** Says chatbots may reinforce what users already believe and their biases are hard to see.
- 3. OpenAI:** Says it monitors its models to keep answers politically neutral.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):